

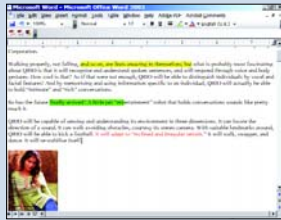


Security Watch

Microsoft Word Vulnerability

The Problem

On October 7, it was made public that a buffer overflow can be exploited in



a Microsoft Word document. An attacker could create a Word document that causes Word to crash when you open the document. What compounds the problem is that it's very likely that someone will open a Word document that comes as an e-mail attachment. Also, IE often opens Word documents in a browser window without asking the user if he wants to open it. The vulnerability has been confirmed in Microsoft Word 2000, but has also been reported in MS Word 2002.

Damages

Secunia rates this as "highly critical." An attacker could gain access to your system and launch DoS attacks.

Precautions

Open only trusted Word documents. IE users, set the security level for the "Internet" security zone to "High," or disable the "File download" setting. At the time of going to print, there was no patch available.

Ambani said that today, Reliance Infocomm has already constructed a pan-India optical fibre network, which will expand to over 100,000 kilometres of optical fibre, and which will connect nearly 5,000 cities and towns by the year end. The network will provide broadband connections to millions of homes and offices, offering the latest technology and direct connectivity to the rest of the world via the FLAG Telecom global network.

India's teledensity—fixed and mobile—is currently at less than nine per cent. Future growth potential is, therefore, staggering.

SERVER SOFTWARE

Microsoft vs Linux. Again!

Microsoft is preparing to hit Linux where it hurts. By designing server software that is secure, modular and affordable, Microsoft hopes to be more competitive against Linux variants. Microsoft's Longhorn—the codename for the successor to its Windows XP operating system—is designed to be very modular in nature.

This should give Longhorn advantages that Linux currently enjoys. Being modular lets a company either use or discard components it does not need.

This flexibility facilitates not just speed of deployment, but also security. Currently, Microsoft's server and desktop operating systems

are based on the same unifying architecture. This leads to extraneous features for a server system, which is an unnecessary security risk.

By virtue of such a design, Microsoft also aims to be more affordable—both in terms of initial investment as well as total cost of ownership, as per maintenance costs. The biggest attraction of Linux is that it is open to tinkering. Governments and businesses can create customised operating systems from the Linux kernel by adding to or dropping services and features they do not need. This flexibility has seen Linux gain a foothold within the market; Microsoft's Longhorn hopes to flatten the competition.

LOGGING PERSONAL INFORMATION

Is India Going The China Way?

All around India, governments are considering edicts, which, if passed, will make it compulsory for cyber-café to log personal information about their customers. First up, the Karnataka Government is seriously mulling over such an act. If passed, a user will need to supply personal information—name and address, to begin with—and show an ID card when using the services of a cyber-café,

HOT

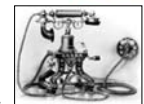
Cell phones



According to Gartner, cellular connections in India will reach 56 million by the end of 2004, a 96 per cent growth over 2003

Landline phones

NOT



India today has more mobiles than landline phones at this point in time (end-October). By September-end, landlines (43.82 m) were slightly more than mobiles (42.97 m)

failing which the person concerned will need to be photographed. The information gathered will need to be maintained for at least one year, during which period it will be open to regular scrutiny by the police force.

The idea is to curb cybercrime. The reaction to this has been largely negative. Apart from the inconvenience it will cause potential customers, the effectiveness of such a register has itself been questioned.

Ashish Saboo, cyber-café owner and President of the Association of Public Internet Access Providers, opines, "...keeping this type of register is completely ineffective to fight computer fraud or cyber-terrorism."

The Web site of the Calcutta police was recently



One Silly Question

What is KBps?



Oh yes, it's Kilobytes per sec, that's easy!
Suraj Anand, Pune



It's Kilobytes per second, for sure!
Amit Tankaria, Mumbai



Frankly, I do not know what it stands for
Asmita Parekar, Mumbai



Ahh, that's supposed to be Kilobytes per second
Mihir Hardikar, Mumbai



It's Kilobytes per second
Ramaswamy Kuppuswamy, Hyderabad